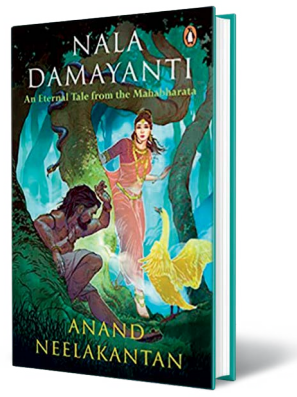
From a prosaic job at the Indian Oil Corporation to top-selling author and screenwriter—not to mention the occasional acting stint—Anand Neelakantan has come a long way. He tasted success with his very first book, *Asura: Tale of the Unvanquished* (2012). "The job had got hectic and boring when I started writing. When *Asura* became a runaway bestseller, it opened up opportunities in both books and television," says Neelakantan. "So, 11 years since my first book, here I am, with 13 books, including the official prequel for *Bahubali*, more than 600 hours of television and two OTT shows to my credit. It happened like a dream."

The high points of Neelakantan's career so far are the three prequel novels he wrote for S.S. Rajamouli's *Bahubali* movie series, the first being *The Rise of Sivagami* (2017). Recalling the experience of writing them, he says, "When S.S. Rajamouli invited me to be the official chronicler of the *Bahubali* prequel, I was scared of my inadequacy. Writing the backstory of an immensely popular film and that too completing a three-book, epic-sized work in less than 18 months, was daunting. However, with more than 40 characters and an intricate plot, I think I redeemed decently well with this project. They remain some of my favourite works."

Not one to rest on his laurels, Neelakantan's success as a writer has paralleled an equally prolific screenwriting career, including the recent *Taj: Divided by Blood* (2023). "It is a different art from writing books, and is more technical and visual," he says. "In *Taj*, I tried to show Mughals as such, without vilifying or glorifying them."

As a writer, Neelakantan specialises in telling tales from the perspective of unusual characters, often the antagonists. While *Asura* was the story of the Ramayana from Ravana's perspective, *Ajaya* (2013) and its sequel are the Mahabharata from Duryodhana's point of view.



NALA DAMAYANTI
by Anand Neelakantan
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ANAND NEELAKANTAN'S SUCCESS AS A WRITER HAS PARALLELED AN EQUALLY PROLIFIC SCREENWRITING CAREER



His latest, *Nala Damayanti*, is no different. "It is not the conventional one, though the story is the same," he says. "Like my other books, this too is told from a different perspective. In my take, Damayanti is the hero and not Nala. Instead of telling it like the poignant and moving sentimental tale of Nala, I have written it like a romantic comedy where fun, positivity and life-affirming values and rationality are highlighted. The conventional story of Nala and Damayanti is a cautionary tale of how fate plays with human destiny. My *Nala Damayanti* is about conquering fate against all odds. In that sense, it is very contemporary."

That's another trait of Neelakantan's writing. Although he retells mythological tales, his books have contemporary undertones. "Using Puranas or history is just a tool to convey my ideas," he says. "In *Asura*, Lanka is present-day India. In *Vanara* (2018), Kishkindha is nothing other than today's India. The same is the case with Mahishmathi or Hastinapura. The characters are contemporary and values are too. Some may criticise it, but I believe literature will have to be true to the period of the writer and not to the period of the story."

The popular tale of Nala and Damayanti from the Mahabharata is one of star-crossed lovers who are parted after a fateful game of dice and eventually reunited, a tale as racy as a Bollywood flick. "Nala Damayanti is a story of enduring love against all odds and misfortunes, It never gets old in any kind of retellings," says Neelakantan.

His version is certainly a page-turner. The not-particularly-reverential tone is refreshing ("Brahma swore and apologised for his Sanskrit"). Neither is the book didactic, at least not in an obvious way. All in all, a nice, entertaining read. Building on the small original story, Neelakantan has woven an elaborate tapestry of characters and situations into his book.